of viewers while ignoring more moderate content. By 2016, users were indeed watching one billion hours every day on YouTube.[5]

YouTubers who were particularly intent on gaining attention noticed that when they posted an outrageous video full of lies, the algorithm rewarded them by recommending the video to numerous users and increasing the YouTubers' popularity and income. In contrast, when they dialled down the outrage and stuck to the truth, the algorithm tended to ignore them. Within a few months of such reinforcement learning, the algorithm turned many YouTubers into trolls.[6]

The social and political consequences were far-reaching. For example, as the journalist Max Fisher documented in his 2022 book, *The Chaos Machine*, YouTube algorithms became an important engine for the rise of the Brazilian far right and for turning Jair Bolsonaro from a fringe figure into Brazil's president.[7] While there were other factors contributing to that political upheaval, it is notable that many of Bolsonaro's chief supporters and aides had originally been YouTubers who rose to fame and power by algorithmic grace.

A typical example is Carlos Jordy, who in 2017 was a city councillor in the small town of Niterói. The ambitious Jordy gained national attention by creating inflammatory YouTube videos that garnered millions of views. His videos warned Brazilians, for example, against conspiracies by schoolteachers to brainwash children and persecute conservative pupils. In 2018, Jordy won a seat in the Brazilian Chamber of Deputies (the lower house of the Brazilian Congress) as one of Bolsonaro's most dedicated supporters. In an interview with Fisher, Jordy frankly said, 'If social media didn't exist, I wouldn't be here [and] Jair Bolsonaro wouldn't be president.' The latter claim may well be a self-serving exaggeration, but there is no denying that social media played an important part in Bolsonaro's rise.

Another YouTuber who won a seat in Brazil's Chamber of Deputies in 2018 was Kim Kataguiri, one of the leaders of the Movimento Brasil Livre (MBL, or Free Brazil Movement). Kataguiri initially used Facebook as his main platform, but his posts were too extreme even for Facebook, which banned some of them for disinformation. So Kataguiri switched over to the more permissive YouTube. In an interview in the MBL headquarters in São Paulo, Kataguiri's aides and other activists explained to Fisher, 'We have something here that we call the dictatorship of the like.' They explained that YouTubers tend to become steadily more extreme, posting untruthful and